

To House A Tiger

I knew I needed help when I ran, the fastest I had in my adult life—full-tilt—out of the water at Wrightsville Beach. I was convinced a tsunami was just behind me. Literal minutes prior, my friends and I had arrived at the far access of the beach, the sun just passing below the horizon; the ocean was that beautiful teal color it only gets when the sand floor hasn't been too disturbed. There was a decent breeze and I could taste the salt it deposited on my lips, but it wasn't enough. I was already panicking when we got there and my friends' only solution was to coax me into the waves with all of my clothes off, slipping our underwear off a leg and pulling it through the crotch before taking it off the other. One friend took me by the hand into gentle waves and for a moment, all of the 'what-ifs' dissipated. All I could feel was the warmth of the ocean around me and how buoyant I was. My mind felt like it was floating with me and I started crying because it felt like I had finally found a reprieve to all of my anxieties, a simple fix to the turmoil in my head. The sky was beautiful and the ocean was beginning to cool, my friends were with me and maybe, everything would be alright. But as the sun began its descent below the horizon, the ocean just below it darkened. I fixated on that far off, almost black line, while my friends wrestled each other below the surface; splashed each other, ducked under and bobbed over the gentle waves, completely oblivious to me: stock still, chest rising and falling faster and faster with each passing moment of the sunset. And as I watched the water stretch out in front of me, moving in tandem with my chest, the ocean at the horizon swelled, broiled, churned. Tensed, like a muscle. The tectonic plates below us were gagging and threatened to spill its contents out on the shore and into Wilmington, North Carolina with life-ending force.

Without a second thought, I was bolting out of the ocean and to the dunes, my legs pumping just as fast as my heart and lungs to keep my systems moving as quickly as that big wave. My friends

didn't notice me flee until I was hugging the dunes and yelling, "Tsunami", over and over again. In the car, I took a sedative and spent the next day in a haze. At least I wasn't panicking.

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I imagine my fear takes shape as a tiger within the cavity of my chest, prowling through sinew and tissue and arteries like savanna grass, ears twitching in the dry heat. It has made its home there for as long as I can remember. It slashes through the muscle of my heart and the capillaries nestled there until I am a bloody, pulped mess.

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I had a dream once when I was about 11 years old in the backseat of my family's minivan, the musty smell and dark blanketing the windows inducing my brain into a feverish nightmare. I can't describe it to you in a way you would understand, I still don't have the words to, but when I awoke I knew, inherently, I was going to die in that plush, velvet seat, my parents running an errand inside the store we were parked in front of. And when I didn't, when the hours passed and I was still breathing, I completely forgot about it.

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It's interesting how one hour can change the trajectory of your life. I wasn't the same after the edible settled in my stomach and Delta-8 rushed my system all at once. I was flooded with memories of my childhood where I spent hours awake, brain refusing to shut off because if it did, my parents would surely die in their sleep, my dogs would die in their sleep, the world would collapse, God would smite me; the list goes on and on. I was responsible for all the functioning systems in my life and in the world and if I were to sleep, I would be the sole source. I became someone who creeps around like Death lurks just out of reach, waiting for me to slip up so it can

lock me within its hold. I spent the next six months like a zombie, convinced I would turn that corner and find Death with open arms; whether in the form of my throat swelling shut, asphyxiation, anaphylaxis from foods I have eaten since I was three years old, my heart stopping, or, plain and simple death.

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I didn't know, by feeling for Death with blind eyes and fumbling hands, I was feeding my tiger, tossing it large cuts of raw beef and whole chickens, giving it a slimy, bloody buffet to feast upon.

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My tiger has been growling to—a low, rumbling sound—since the first time I began obsessing over my parents dying. It carried me through adolescence, threatening to grow heavier each time I stepped to that metaphorical edge of the unknown. When I thought, again, I was going to be swallowed by a tsunami, the tiger started to roar, this awful, grinding thing, unsheathing its claws just a little bit more, piercing into my sternum, letting the chambers of my heart open to the stale air of my lungs.

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Two months after I ran full tilt out of the Atlantic Ocean, I took Prozac for the first time. As soon as it passed my tongue, I shouldered my way through the six inches of drywall between our hotel rooms and shook and sobbed over my mother lain out in her queen size bed with my father, convinced I would have an allergic reaction. She turned on *Upside Down* from Curious George, the song I listened to every night before bed over and over and over again until I fell asleep as a child, and I did my Duolingo lesson for the night, those tears falling on my phone as I conjugated verbs. The rubber coating of the pill felt like it was stuck in my throat, lodged in my

airway, as Jack Johnson sang, and I learned how to say *I couldn't love you more* in a language I will never use.

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I'm better now, at least a little bit. I understand more of my brain, more of my tiger. It doesn't know better than its instinct, than its need to prey upon the good in my life. I've learned how to quiet its sound, if only just barely.

Sometimes, still, even with a different concoction of medication and therapy and exposure and new triggers, my tiger has me run out into the open meadow and through the biting cold creek. It makes me bare my ankles to its rushing waters and submerge my face until my cheeks go numb so that I may better overcome my shame. To take a second and breathe, to notice how the pounding of my heart is purely from exertion and not from attack. To look around at the trees and at the flowers and at the sway of the grass in the wind, listen to the goldfinches and cardinals and redtail hawks hidden in branches and the bubbling of the water falling over moss-covered rocks, know that the sun is still shining and the world is still turning. It wants me to dry off in a sprint to the edge of a cliff and push me off. But when I'm in the biting cold of that creek, letting the eddies nip at the delicate skin of my ankles, I force myself to stop. The tiger submits, and I step out of the water and into a swatch of grass, curl up in the soil. Here, I am safe to relax, to breathe, to let go of the what-ifs, the great weight of the world I carry on my shoulders. Here, I am safe to sleep.